Era (CE) literally constituted a watershed moment in Indian and global history.

One of the earliest known agricultural settlements in the Indian subcontinent has been located in Mehrgarh, near Quetta in Baluchistan, and dates back to around 7000 BCE.[12] The settlement lived in mud-brick huts, grew wheat and barley and herded cattle, sheep and goats. These are typical features of a village as the emergence of agriculture and settlement marks a radical departure from the nomadic ways of living. That this occurred in Baluchistan is all the more remarkable because even as recently as in the 20th century it was known for its tribal communities and peripatetic ways of living. Commenting on their pastoral practices, a Census official in 1921 noted that the Balochi people had ‘discovered the secret of perpetual motion’ and that one third of the indigenous population were nomads, ‘pure and simple’.[13] Nevertheless, in the ancient past, the region around Mehrgarh showed clear signs of continuous settlement over millennia and a gradual process of urbanization.[14] The first traces of rural to urban migration could potentially be traced to this part of the Indian subcontinent.

Mehrgarh and its surrounding region are considered to belong to the pre-Harappan era, dated between the late fourth millennium BCE and 2600 BCE. Between then and 1900 BCE, what we now call the mature Harappan civilization flourished along the Indus Valley and beyond, covering an area of roughly one million square kilometres from the Ganga–Yamuna doab (or land between rivers) in the east to the present-day Pakistan–Iran border in the west and extending to Gujarat and Rajasthan.[15] There is considerable evidence of large urban centres and trade, and hence the introduction of a new form of migration in the subcontinent involving mercantile links. The Harappan people were also of different racial types, pointing towards different streams of migrations. But the civilization remains a mystery even a century after its excavation and rediscovery due to its undeciphered inscriptions. Equally puzzling is its decline and the abandoning of many sites from around 1900 BCE. One theory for this decline, and presumably outmigration, are droughts or floods due to climate change.